Interview Preparation Guide

Stop Stressing. Start Performing. Get the Job.

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Framework Attribution: This guide is based on Sam Owens' I Hate Job Interviews: Stop Stressing. Start Performing. Get the Job You Want" methodology, adapted with my insider recruiting knowledge from 500+ hires and 20,000+ resume reviews.

Introduction: Why Most People Fail Interviews

I've been on both sides of the table.

I bombed interviews early in my career. Now I've hired 500+ people as a recruiter.

Here's what I learned: **The best candidate doesn't get the job. The best person at interviewing gets the job.**

Good news for you.

You can beat more qualified candidates if you prepare better. Most people don't prepare enough.

They prepare 1-2 hours for an interview, prepare the wrong things, and wonder why they didn't get an offer.

Interviewing is a skill. You can learn it. This guide shows you how.

Kill These Lies First

Let's destroy the myths keeping you from interview success.

"Just be yourself"

Which self? The one that binge-watched Netflix all weekend?

You have multiple selves. Be your best prepared self.

"I can't prepare without knowing the questions"

Wrong. There are 5 main question types. You can prepare for all of them.

"Interviewers are experts"

Most hiring managers get zero training. They're winging it too. Also, most don't do any preparation for the interview beyond looking at your resume.

"I lost because someone was more qualified"

Yes, this happens. We can't change how qualified you are compared to others but we can prepare the best we can for the highest chance of success.

The 10-Hour Prep Framework

Most candidates spend 1 hour preparing. You're about to spend 10 hours.

That's your advantage.

Research: 3 hours

- 1 hour: Company basics
- 2 hours: Informational interviews with employees

Formulation: 3 hours

- 1 hour: Create 7-10 power examples
- 2 hours: Build frameworks for different question types

Practice: 4 hours

- 1-2 hours: Practice out loud alone
- 2 hours: Mock interviews with feedback

10 hours for a job you'll spend 40+ hours/week at for years?

Yes, I know it's hard but do it.

Part 1: The Research Phase

Company Research (1 Hour)

Before you walk in, you need to know:

- **Company history**: Where they've been, where they're going
- **Mission and values**: These will come up in your answers
- **Financials**: Revenue, profits, growth trajectory (basics only unless it's a finance role)
- **Products/services**: Actually use the product if you can
- **Current news**: What's happening with them right now?

Most of this is on their website, Wikipedia, or recent news articles.

Inside Information (2 Hours) - Your Secret Weapon

This separates good candidates from great ones.

Talk to people who actually work there.

You'll get:

- Real insights Google can't give you
- Names to drop in interviews (have people inside the company advocate for you)
- Problems the team is actually facing
- Insider language (the jargon they use in the company shows you understand them)

How to get these conversations:

1. Search LinkedIn for 1st/2nd degree connections
2. Message: "Hey [name], interviewing for [role] at [company]. Can I grab 15 minutes of your time?"
3. Ask good questions (below)
4. Take notes
5. Send thanks

Note: If you know someone who works in the company or a friend of a friend, talk to them this way.

What to ask:

- What's the culture really like?
- What does success look like in this role?
- What challenges is the team facing?
- What do you wish you knew before starting?
- What advice for someone interviewing?

Do 2-3 of these.

Will you get rejected a lot? Yes. But you only need to talk to one person to get insider information.

Part 2: The Formulation Phase

Create Your Power Examples (7-10 Stories)

Power examples = stories that prove you can do the job.

They're your foundation for every answer.

How to pick them:

1. Read job description
2. Find top 7-10 skills they want
3. Match one story to each skill

Where stories come from:

- Previous jobs (best)
- School projects
- Volunteer work
- Side projects
- Anywhere you've done relevant work

Good power examples are:

✅ Specific ("March 2024, led team of 5" not "I often worked with teams")
✅ Quantified (numbers, metrics, outcomes)
✅ Recent (last 2-3 years)
✅ About YOU (not just "the team")

Bad power examples:

❌ "I'm a good communicator"
❌ "We increased sales" (who's we?)
❌ Vague, no numbers, no specifics

Example Power Story #1: Leadership

Skill: Team leadership and project management

Story: "In Q2 2024, I led a cross-functional team of 5 engineers and 2 designers to launch a new mobile app feature. We had a tight 6-week deadline. I organized daily standups, created a shared project tracker, and assigned clear ownership for each milestone.

When we hit a technical blocker in week 4, I reprioritized tasks and brought in a senior engineer to unblock us. We launched on time, and the feature drove a 35% increase in user engagement within the first month."

Why it works: Specific timeline, clear numbers, shows leadership actions, quantified result.

Example Power Story #2: Problem-Solving

Skill: Analytical thinking and data analysis

Story: "At my last company, our customer support costs increased 40% year-over-year, but nobody knew why. I pulled 6 months of ticket data and discovered that 60% of tickets were about the same 3 issues.

I created a simple knowledge base with solutions to those 3 problems and added links to our product interface. Within 3 months, support tickets dropped 28%, saving the company approximately $45K annually. The knowledge base is still being used today."

Why it works: Identified specific problem, shows analytical approach, concrete financial impact, lasting solution.

Example Power Story #3: Communication/Stakeholder Management

Skill: Working with difficult stakeholders

Story: "I was managing a marketing campaign when our biggest client suddenly demanded we change the entire creative direction 1 week before launch. The design team was frustrated because they'd already completed the work.

Instead of pushing back immediately, I scheduled a call with the client to understand their concerns. I discovered they'd received negative feedback from their CEO. I worked with our team to create 3 new options that addressed the CEO's feedback while keeping 70% of our original work.

We presented all options, the client chose one, and we delivered on time. They increased their contract value by 30% the following quarter."

Why it works: Shows diplomacy, problem-solving under pressure, specific actions taken, business outcome.

Part 3: Question Frameworks

Now that you have your power examples, let's learn how to deploy them for different question types.

How many examples should you prepare?

- **Behavioral questions (SPAR)**: Prepare 7-10 stories (your power examples)
- **Scenario questions (Home Base)**: Practice 5-7 different frameworks/approaches
- **About You questions (SEE)**: You'll reuse your behavioral stories, just reframe them

The beauty of this system: **You don't need 50 different stories. Your 7-10 power examples can answer most questions.**

Framework #1: SPAR Model (For Behavioral Questions)

Behavioral questions ask about your past experiences:

- "Tell me about a time when..."
- "Give me an example of..."
- "Describe a situation where..."

Use SPAR: **Situation, Problem, Action, Result**

S - Situation (10-15 seconds) Set the scene. Keep it brief. Don't waste time here.

P - Problem (15-20 seconds) Create tension. This is what makes people want to keep listening.

A - Action (60-90 seconds) This is the meat. Explain what YOU did (not your team). Use the "rule of three" - break your action into 3 steps.

R - Result (15-20 seconds) Quantify the outcome. Tie it in a bow.

Example:

Question: "Tell me about a time you solved a complex problem."

Situation: "Last year at my previous company, I was the account manager for our digital marketing clients."

Problem: "A few months in, my boss asked me to figure out which clients were most valuable to us. We'd never done this before, and there was no clear definition of 'value.'"

Action: "I approached this in three steps. First, I created a scorecard with three metrics: revenue, profitability, and credibility score. Second, I calculated hours spent per client and created efficiency ratios. Third, I presented my findings to leadership with recommendations."

Result: "We shifted strategy to focus on our highest-impact clients. Six months later, we grew revenue from those clients by 25%, which was a major contribution to the firm's growth that year."

Framework #2: Home Base Model (For Scenario Questions)

Scenario questions are hypothetical:

- "How would you approach...?"
- "What would you do if...?"
- "How would you handle...?"

These are the hardest questions because they're wide open.

Use the Home Base model: **Establish, Explore, Summarize**

Visual Guide: The Home Base Model

```
                PATH 1
                (Specific idea)
                    |
  PATH 2 -------- HOME BASE -------- PATH 3
(Specific idea)   (Foundation)    (Specific idea)
                    |
                 PATH 4
                (Specific idea)
```

Think of it like a hub-and-spoke:

- **HOME BASE** = Your central framework/approach
- **PATHS** = Specific ideas that branch out from your framework
- You explore each path, then return to summarize

Step 1: Establish Your Home Base (20-30 seconds) Start with a framework or approach. This is your "map."

Templates:

- "I'd approach this in three phases..."
- "There are four key areas I'd look at..."
- "My process would involve three steps..."

Step 2: Explore Each Path (60-90 seconds each) Go through each part of your framework. Add details. Show your thinking.

Step 3: Summarize (15-20 seconds) Tie it together. Restate your framework.

Example:

Question: "How would you approach your first 90 days in this role?"

Establish: "I'd break my first 90 days into three phases: Learn, Contribute, and Scale."

Explore: "In the Learn phase (first 30 days), I'd meet with key stakeholders, understand current processes, and identify quick wins.

In the Contribute phase (days 31-60), I'd execute on those quick wins to build credibility and start taking on bigger projects.

In the Scale phase (days 61-90), I'd start implementing larger initiatives and thinking about long-term strategy."

Summarize: "So in summary: Learn, Contribute, Scale. That's how I'd structure my first quarter."

Framework #3: SEE Model (For "About You" Questions)

These questions ask about your qualities:

- "What's your biggest weakness?"
- "Why should we hire you?"
- "What's your work style?"

Use SEE: **Statement, Example, Effect**

S - Statement: Say it directly. No hedging.

E - Example: Give a specific instance.

E - Effect: Explain why this matters for the role.

Example:

Question: "What's your biggest weakness?"

Statement: "I tend to take on too much because I have a hard time saying no."

Example: "Last quarter, I agreed to three major projects simultaneously and ended up working late nights to meet all the deadlines."

Effect: "I've learned to be more strategic about what I commit to. Now I evaluate new requests against my current workload and the impact of the work. For this role, that means I'll be focused on the highest-impact projects rather than spreading myself too thin."

Part 4: Handling Difficult Questions

Weakness Questions

Don't say "I'm a perfectionist" or "I work too hard."

Pick a real weakness that:

1. Won't disqualify you
2. You're actively fixing
3. Shows self-awareness

Template:

"I [weakness], which led to [consequence]. I'm fixing this by [action]. I've already seen [progress]."

Example:

"I tend to take on too much at once, which led to me missing a deadline last quarter. Now I evaluate new requests against my current workload before committing. Last month I completed three major projects ahead of schedule."

Salary Questions

If they ask first: "I'm looking for competitive compensation for this role and market. What's the range you have budgeted?"

If you must give a number: Give a range based on market research, and say "depending on the full compensation package."

Gap Questions

Be honest but brief. Don't over-explain.

"I took time off to [reason]. During that time I [stayed sharp by...]. Now I'm ready to jump back in."

Illegal/Inappropriate Questions

Some interviewers ask illegal stuff (age, marital status, religion, etc.). Options:

1. **Redirect**: "Is there a specific concern about how this relates to the role?"
2. **Politely decline**: "I'd prefer to focus on my qualifications for the position."
3. **Just answer** if it's harmless and you don't care

Weird Questions

Some interviewers ask wacky stuff ("If you were an animal..."). They want to see how you think.

Template: Answer + "because" + (optional) tie back to job

"I'd be a golden retriever because I'm eager to please and work well with others. That's how I approach teamwork at work too."

Part 5: Your Questions to Ask

Always have 3-5 questions ready. This is your chance to interview THEM.

Questions that make you look good:

- "What does success look like in this role in the first 6 months?"
- "What are the biggest challenges facing the team right now?"
- "How would you describe the culture here?"
- "What do you like most about working here?"
- "What's your management style?" (if asking the hiring manager)

Questions NOT to ask:

- Anything you could Google (shows you didn't prepare)
- "What does this company do?" (seriously, don't)
- Only questions about benefits/vacation (looks like you only care about perks)

Part 6: The Practice Phase

This is where 90% of candidates quit.

Don't be them.

Phase 1: Read-Through (30-60 min)

Say your answers out loud.

You'll hear what's awkward. Fix it now.

Phase 2: Memorize (60-90 min)

Learn your frameworks and stories.

Phase 3: Mock Interviews (2-3 hours)

This is the most important part.

Get someone to interview you. Can be:

- Friend
- Colleague
- Career coach (best)
- Your spouse

- AI

Mock interview rules:

1. Treat it like it's real
2. No stopping mid-answer
3. Feedback at the END only
4. Do 2 minimum

Why practice works:

It reveals your weaknesses before they cost you the job.

That awkward pause? Fix it now, not in the real interview.

Most candidates skip this. That's your advantage.

Part 7: Interview Day

Before the Interview

- Get there 10-15 minutes early (no more, no less)
- Turn off your phone
- Use the bathroom
- Review your power examples one last time
- Take 3 deep breaths: breathe in 1 second, breathe out 4 seconds, repeat

During the Interview

First impression tips:

- Strong handshake
- Eye contact
- Smile
- Mirror their energy level

During questions:

- If you need more time to think before answering a question, pause for 2-4 seconds before answering (shows you're thinking)
- If you don't understand, ask them to clarify
- It's ok to say "That's a great question, let me think for a second"
- Watch for engagement cues (nodding, leaning in)

Body language:

- Sit up straight

- Don't cross your arms
- Use hand gestures naturally
- Maintain eye contact 70-80% of the time

Closing:

- Ask your questions
- Restate your interest: "I'm very interested in this role and would love to move forward"
- Ask about next steps

After the Interview

Send a thank you email within 24 hours.

Template:

Hi [Name],

Thank you for taking the time to speak with me today about the [role] position.

I really enjoyed learning about [specific thing they mentioned] and I'm excited about the opportunity to [specific contribution you'd make].

[Optional: Reference to something personal you connected on]

I look forward to hearing about next steps.

Best,
[Your name]

Common Mistakes That Kill Offers

❌ **Talking too much** - Answer the question. Then stop.

❌ **Trashing previous employers** - Stay diplomatic.

❌ **No specific examples** - Everything needs details.

❌ **Not asking questions** - Shows you don't care.

❌ **No follow-up** - Send that thank you email.

❌ **Lying** - They'll find out. Don't.

❌ **Showing up unprepared** - If you don't care to prep, they won't care to hire.

Quick Reference Cheat Sheet

Pre-Interview Checklist

☐ Research company (1 hour)
☐ Informational interviews (2 hours)
☐ Create 7-10 power examples (1 hour)
☐ Prepare SPAR stories (1 hour)
☐ Prepare scenario frameworks (1 hour)
☐ Practice out loud (1 hour)
☐ Mock interview #1 (1 hour)
☐ Mock interview #2 (1 hour)
☐ Prepare questions to ask (30 min)
☐ Plan outfit (15 min)

Note - Online interviews:

☐ Test your internet connection
☐ Audio
☐ Video
☐ No clutter in the background
☐ Make sure you are in a quiet place
☐ The camera should be level with your face so you are not looking too far up or down

Day-Of Checklist

☐ Review power examples
☐ Arrive 10-15 min early
☐ Phone on silent
☐ Bring printed resume
☐ Bring notebook
☐ Smile and make eye contact

Post-Interview Checklist

☐ Send thank you email within 24 hours
☐ Note what went well/needs improvement
☐ Follow up if no response by their timeline

Final Thoughts From Me

I've seen incredibly talented people bomb interviews. Many times it's because they haven't prepared or didn't have feedback on how to act in interviews.

I've seen average candidates get offers. They showed up ready.

Interviewing is a skill. Practice makes you better.

Use this guide. Do the 10 hours. Watch your interview performance transform.

Want personalized help with your interview prep?

I offer 1-on-1 coaching and resume reviews for professionals targeting high-paying roles

Email me: james@jamesbugden.com for more information

This guide is based on Sam Owens' "I Hate Job Interviews" methodology, which I've adapted based on my experience hiring as a Senior Recruiter.

Support the author and buy his book to understand the full context behind his framework. It's the best interview preparation guide I've read.

Source: Owens, Sam. "I Hate Job Interviews: Stop Stressing, Start Performing, Get the Job You Want." HarperCollins Leadership, 2024.